

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 5 OF SIX

The Penthouse Where Everybody Had a Story

Character stories, dialogue and consequential choices

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 5. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P161	P162	P163	P164	P165	P166	P167	P168
2. Ready for conversation	P169	P170	P171	P172	P173	P174	P175	P176
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P177	P178	P179	P180	P181	P182	P183	P184
4. Here for the atmosphere	P185	P186	P187	P188	P189	P190	P191	P192
5. Open to a wildcard	P193	P194	P195	P196	P197	P198	P199	P200

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Hotel Charged Me for My Own Entrance

The hotel had put my face on the elevator doors. Nigga, every time somebody wanted the thirty-second floor, they had to split my head down the middle.

I stood in front of it with Tank. Two tourists waited behind us. One had a camera. The other had the expression of a woman who had already heard why her husband needed the camera.

'Who approved that?' I asked. Tank looked at the doors. 'You. You said larger than life.' 'Nigga, I meant the photograph. Not the forehead.'

The doors opened through my nose. Shawna stood inside wearing a blue dress that had ended three conversations on the way upstairs. Mine nearly became the fourth.

'Baby. You coming?' 'Depends what happens when I arrive.' 'You help Rosa move the food.'

Tank got in first. Nigga moved fast when somebody gave romance a practical ending.

The penthouse was supposed to hold a game night. I had rented the whole floor, hired a singer, ordered a champagne fountain and told the hotel I wanted the room to feel intimate. They had installed enough speakers to introduce intimacy to the surrounding county.

Mercedes was at the piano with the singer. She wanted one clean run through her new arrangement before anybody started talking over it. Porsche had both phones out and was threatening the lighting technician with a photograph of what his amber setting did to her shoes.

Rosa wanted dinner hot. Tank wanted to sit beside Rosa. Shawna wanted the bedroom key I had somehow given to the man tuning the piano. Everybody had a clear objective. Mine was to make this look intentional.

'Nigga, why the piano man got our room?' 'He asked for a key.' 'He meant a musical key.'

My wife held out her hand. I went and fetched the other kind.

By the windows, a casino host was showing a guest the private bar. The guest had brought cocaine and an opinion about every business in Nevada. His opinion arrived first. His jacket followed on a waiter's arm after Porsche decided both needed to leave her piano alone.

'He said he's an investor,' I told her. 'Then he can invest in the fucking elevator.'

Porsche handed the jacket to the host. Tank held the door. The guest kept explaining his idea while the lift carried him and his belongings toward a different audience.

I liked Porsche. She could remove a whole subplot without explaining symbolism.

Mercedes tried the first line. Conversation dropped away in pieces. Shawna leaned against me. I slid a hand to her waist. She let it stay there, which immediately improved my opinion of the architecture.

'We could go upstairs,' I whispered. 'This is the top floor.' 'Nigga, emotionally.' 'Emotionally, you still owe Rosa two trays.'

I carried the trays.

On the long low table, the games were ready. Stories about bartenders, drivers, detectives, families and people whose decisions refused to stay simple. The hotel had supplied a second sofa so somebody could watch without being assigned a controller. It was a small miracle. Usually a hotel charges extra for understanding a sentence.

Tank dropped onto it and patted the place beside him. Rosa put down the last dish and sat. My brother's whole face changed. Same nigga who could make a doorway look nervous, looking at her like the night had finally started.

'You feeding me?' he asked. 'You got hands.' 'I'm being romantic.' 'Then use both and pass the plate.'

He passed it. Romance survived the adjustment.

I stood in front of the screen. The hotel lights caught my blue jacket. A guest by the bar raised his glass and said I had turned a Crip colour into a room service surcharge.

'Nigga, this is tailored.' 'So is the bill,' Tank said.

I had prepared a speech. Mercedes looked up from the piano and shook her head once. Not angry. Busy. She wanted her music, and the room was finally giving it to her.

I folded the speech without opening it.

These were separate invitations. Somebody could want a game. Somebody could want a song. Somebody could want to hear what a character meant without racing an answer. Nobody had to join the noise because I had paid to make it loud.

Shawna pulled me down beside her. 'Pick something with people in it.' 'Baby, people love me.' 'I want to hear them finish a sentence.'

Tank laughed hard enough to lose a shrimp. Rosa caught it on his plate. That nigga had married well.

I opened the first story. The door to the hallway stayed shut, the bedroom key stayed in my wife's hand, and for one promising moment the most interesting voice in the penthouse did not belong to me.

P161 / A PLACE TO START

Coffee Talk

Edition considered: PC first game

Listen to customers in a late-night café, where preparing a drink creates space for intimate conversations and gradually unfolding personal stories.

What you do. Read conversations, prepare requested drinks and follow the people who return to the counter with different concerns.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Choose Main Story with manual text advance; timed Challenge Mode is a different experience, and ingredient selection still needs attention.

Why it might click. Coffee Talk makes a café counter into a place to get to know recurring people. The fantasy setting puts a fresh surface on work, romance, identity, and belonging. Serving drinks influences story branches; the appeal is noticing a person's request and watching relationships develop.

The full catch. Use the main story with manual text advance; avoid timed Challenge mode. Expect substantial reading and ingredient selection. Drink choices can change story branches. Check the brewing interface and text controls; any decorative latte work is a separate hold/drag question.

Try this first. Choose the main Story mode and manual text advance. Serve one early request, then stay for the conversation it supports. Notice whether ingredients add pleasure or interrupt listening; check the exact edition's controls before settling in.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Barista Knows Why My Wife Is Smiling

I leaned over the penthouse coffee counter and told Shawna I knew exactly what she needed. Nigga, I had been married long enough to understand why she enjoyed hearing me say that.

'Go on,' she said. I reached for a cup. 'Something hot. Complicated. Worth staying up for.' 'Coffee, Aiden.'

Tank laughed into his saucer. The bartender waited with the patience of a man being paid hourly for my courtship.

Coffee Talk had people arriving with more on their minds than the drink. Mercedes wanted to hear one finish. I started predicting the problem. She turned the little screen toward herself.

'Nigga, let the customer speak.' 'I'm establishing rapport.' 'You're establishing noise.'

I made Shawna's coffee while she listened. Put the cup down without an introduction. She took a sip and caught my sleeve before I could walk away.

'That,' she said, 'was what I needed.' Tank lifted his saucer. 'Write it down, my nigga. You solved one.'

Aiden's verdict. Bring this to a night that wants conversation over spectacle. My wife got her coffee; the nigga advertising himself as a beverage remains under review.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports the first game's premise and drink-driven story. The identified secondary walkthrough separates the main story from timed Challenge objectives; this is a mode-specific recommendation. Manual advance, brewing and hold comfort still need checking in the chosen edition. The whole-game pace field remains unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/914800/>

Source 2: <https://www.trueachievements.com/game/Coffee-Talk/walkthrough>

P162 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

Edition considered: PC sequel

Return to familiar café company for new conversations and drink-making, with another set of relationships to follow across the nights together.

What you do. Prepare drinks, follow customer conversations and explore the latte-art interface if its particular form of interaction interests you.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Returning relationships and recipes add tracking; fluid latte-art controls may require drawing, dragging or sustained pointer movement.

Why it might click. The second Coffee Talk offers more café conversations with returning and new fantasy customers, additional drink ingredients, and latte-art play. It suits an appetite for spending more time with this particular world rather than racing through a chain of dramatic reveals.

The full catch. Recipes and returning relationships can increase the things to remember. The official description includes fluid-simulation latte art, so drawing or held-pointer demands need checking separately. Nothing about the calm presentation establishes a complete absence of fiddly inputs.

Try this first. Make an early drink and follow one customer's situation. Try the art interface only if it interests you; inspect how to proceed if it does not. Decide whether the return feels welcoming or depends too much on previous familiarity.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P162 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Butterfly Looks Like It Owes Child Support

I told the bartender I could draw a butterfly in the milk. Shawna watched me take possession of the cup with the confidence that usually preceded a hotel damage charge.

The result had one enormous wing and a body shaped like a threat. Tank looked down. 'Nigga, that butterfly got warrants.'

Mercedes wanted hibiscus. Porsche wanted to show her something on the game screen. Neither had requested an exhibition of my dairy talents, but success rarely waits for permission to announce itself. 'It's abstract,' I said. Shawna turned the cup. 'Now it's fleeing.'

The second Coffee Talk brought another night of people carrying stories into a familiar place. Porsche leaned closer when a conversation caught her. Mercedes stopped checking her phone.

I almost explained how I had created the atmosphere. The bartender slid a proper drink in front of me and quietly took away my brush.

Shawna tasted the tea. 'Lovely.' 'You mean my butterfly?' 'Baby, I mean the thing somebody else finished.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose another evening at the counter if the people still interest you. My butterfly has been denied entry, but its fleeing silhouette remains emotionally convincing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1663220/>

P163 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

VA-11 Hall-A: Cyberpunk Bartender Action

Edition considered: PC release

Work behind a cyberpunk bar where mixing drinks gives you time with distinctive customers, their problems and the life outside the counter.

What you do. Read customer exchanges, follow drink recipes and serve mixtures while learning more about the people who visit the bar.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Reading, recipes and customer preferences need attention, alongside sexual conversation and alcohol themes; test the actual mixing controls.

Why it might click. The game uses bartending to frame a series of conversations about life in a high-tech, unequal city. Drinks influence which stories unfold. Its attraction is the contrast between large political systems and the specific people living, working, joking, and struggling inside them.

The full catch. Reading, recipe selection, and remembering customer preferences are real parts of the experience. Sexual conversation, alcohol, and adult subject matter belong to its tone. Check ingredient operations and any mixing or waiting controls rather than inferring simplicity from the visual-novel label.

Try this first. Complete one customer order with the recipe information available on screen. Then judge the conversation itself: are these people enjoyable company, and is the bar routine a satisfying rhythm rather than unwanted clerical work?

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Cocktail Was Named After Me and Nobody Wanted Two

The bartender asked what I wanted to call my signature drink. I said Aiden After Midnight. Tank asked whether it came with an apology in the morning.

'Nigga, it comes with confidence.' 'That's the ingredient I'm worried about.'

VA-11 Hall-A put a different kind of bar in front of us. Neon, people with difficult lives, drinks that gave them somewhere to start talking. Mercedes pulled up a chair.

I tried to make our actual bartender explain my creation to a woman waiting for water. Shawna caught my eye across the counter.

'She asked for water.' 'I heard her.' 'Then why are you naming yourself at her?'

I passed the water. The woman thanked me and returned to her own conversation. Astonishingly, the room survived without learning what my cocktail meant.

Tank tasted my drink and set it down. 'Nigga, this tastes like you had an argument with a lemon.' Shawna slid it toward me. 'Good. You two can resolve it privately.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the neon bar for its people and their messy nights. The actual bartender may confiscate my lemon argument without compromising anybody's fictional drinking order.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/447530/>

P164 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Red Strings Club

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a cyberpunk story about emotion and influence through unusual work, conversations and choices that question what helping another person means.

What you do. Shape objects, prepare drinks, use telephone conversations and make choices while following the story's questions about emotional influence.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Object shaping can require precision; several interaction types and morally difficult themes need checking beyond the point-and-click label.

Why it might click. This cyberpunk conspiracy story asks what happiness and emotional freedom mean. Its unusual sequence of bartending, implant pottery, and phone impersonation gives those arguments different forms; you manipulate both objects and conversations while learning what a corporation intends.

The full catch. The store explicitly describes a lathe and cocktail manipulation, which makes pointer precision and held movement significant checks. This is not safely described as dialogue-only. Its emotional manipulation and corporate-control themes may also feel sharper than a relaxed conversation game.

Try this first. Inspect the first hands-on task as soon as it appears. Determine whether its movement is enjoyable and whether the offered controls work for you. A compelling ethical question is not an obligation to tolerate an irritating interface.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Clay Knows My Hands Better Than My Alibi

I said the pot I had made looked like a heart. Shawna said it looked like a heart after I explained my expenses. Tank turned it over and asked where the other half went.

The Red Strings Club had us talking about emotion, influence and the difference between helping somebody and deciding what they should feel. I was strongly in favour of people feeling impressed.

Mercedes wanted to turn the object herself. I kept pointing at the screen. She held out her hand until I remembered the mouse belonged in it.

'Nigga, move.' 'I'm assisting.' 'Then assist yourself out of my light.'

At the real bar, a guest was promising Porsche he could change her entire career. Porsche asked whether he could change his seat instead.

Shawna watched me watching. 'You hearing the theme?' 'Baby, I've been hearing themes all night.'

She put my crooked clay heart beside my drink. 'Then hear this one. I like you better when you ask.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the strange club when influence itself sounds worth questioning. My clay heart may attend, provided the nigga holding it stops diagnosing everybody else's feelings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/589780/>

P165 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Neo Cab

Edition considered: PC release

Meet passengers whose conversations reveal a troubled city, while a driver's relationships, money and emotional state complicate the choices ahead.

What you do. Read passenger exchanges, choose responses and consider the relationships, ratings and resources affected by the driver's decisions.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Money, ratings and emotion restrictions create pressure; check text flow and map/menu operations despite the declared mouse-only option.

Why it might click. Neo Cab is a visual novel about Lina, a human driver in an increasingly automated city. Passengers become sources of stories and possible leads in her search. Her emotional state affects available responses, giving conversations a connection to the strain of working and surviving.

The full catch. Do not confuse its driving premise with a promise about vehicle controls: the inspected listing calls it a visual novel and declares a mouse-only option. Money, ratings, and emotion restrictions can still create pressure. Check reading flow and map/menu operations.

Try this first. Follow an early passenger conversation through to its outcome. Look at how a mood change affects the next available response. Decide whether that constraint deepens the character or makes the conversation feel less enjoyable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Driver Has Heard My Seduction Speech Before

I put on driving gloves inside the suite. Tank looked at the carpet. 'Nigga, where you taking us? The lamp?'

Neo Cab's conversations began with somebody needing a ride. Mine began with Shawna needing me to stop pretending the sofa was a luxury vehicle. I offered her the front seat anyway.

'What's the fare?' she asked. 'A kiss.' 'Hotel already charged me for the room. I'm negotiating.'

Mercedes sat with the game and read the passenger's reply. A person could want a destination and still bring a whole different problem into the car. She wanted to hear it.

I started a story about the last woman who admired my driving. Shawna looked at me. 'That was me.' 'Baby, I remember my best reviews.'

Tank produced the actual car keys. 'You left these in the champagne bucket.'

I removed the gloves. My wife moved closer on the sofa. Apparently the driver could have a pleasant evening after admitting he was parked.

Aiden's verdict. Invite the passenger stories when conversation and compromise appeal. My driving gloves stay on the table until the nigga wearing them identifies an actual vehicle.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/794540/>

P166 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Eliza

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a story about scripted emotional support, work and listening, where the gap between a helpful conversation and a performance becomes interesting.

What you do. Read conversations, choose responses and follow the character's work and relationships as the story questions how support is delivered.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Substantial dialogue explores personal distress and counselling technology; check text pacing and whether the subject feels welcome tonight.

Why it might click. Eliza follows Evelyn as she works as a human proxy for an AI counseling program and reconnects with people from her past. Fully voiced characters and a contemporary setting carry questions about work, responsibility, technical power, and whether simulated care meets real needs.

The full catch. The subject includes personal distress and the limits of counseling technology. Consider whether that is welcome material tonight. Expect substantial dialogue and choices; verify text pacing and navigation. This is a fictional story, not an instruction manual for supporting another person.

Try this first. Read an early work scene and a conversation outside it. Compare the constrained professional role with Evelyn's own voice. Continue if the contrast makes you curious, rather than because the subject seems worthy enough to require homework.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Earpiece Told Me to Shut the Fuck Up

Shawna stood behind the casino's decorative screen and fed me reassuring sentences through an earpiece. I delivered the first one to Tank with my hand over my heart.

'I hear the weight of your concern.' Tank looked at his plate. 'Nigga, I asked where the sauce was.'

Eliza had started an argument about scripted empathy. I intended to prove that warmth could make any line convincing. Shawna sent the next instruction.

'Ask a follow-up.' I leaned closer. 'How long have you wanted the sauce?'

Mercedes laughed so hard she put the controller down. Rosa walked past me, gave Tank the sauce and kissed his head. The entire therapeutic performance lost to a small bowl.

I took out the earpiece. 'Baby, you were setting me up.' 'You volunteered to demonstrate understanding.'

She came around the screen and sat beside me. I asked whether she wanted anything. She said a quiet minute. Nigga, the first unscripted request was the hardest one.

Aiden's verdict. Try this when the distance between listening and performing concern feels interesting. The sauce arrived without an earpiece, which has complicated my theory of professional warmth.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/716500/>

P167 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Citizen Sleeper

Edition considered: PC first game

Build a precarious life through dice and daily choices, with relationships and meaningful opportunities competing for the resources available each cycle.

What you do. Allocate dice, choose tasks, manage resources and follow relationships while deciding what can be done during each cycle.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. No timed input is declared, but resource shortages, cycle clocks and interconnected choices create substantial planning pressure.

Why it might click. Citizen Sleeper turns life on a crowded station into choices about work, friendships, resources, and survival. Assigning dice creates a clear connection between what you can do this cycle and what you care about. Its characters make those allocations feel personal rather than merely numerical.

The full catch. Steam declares playable without timed input, but the story uses resource pressure and advancing clocks. Several systems and ongoing relationships need attention. That declaration does not verify hold-free controls; inspect dice placement, text size, and the station interface.

Try this first. Spend one cycle slowly, explaining to yourself what each chosen action will cost or advance. Meet somebody whose situation interests you. Notice whether the limited opportunities feel engaging or like a second schedule to manage.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Rolled Four Problems and Called Them Opportunity

I shook the dice beside the penthouse window like I was about to win the hotel. Tank watched them land. 'Nigga, those numbers don't even buy breakfast.'

Citizen Sleeper gave us a life built from limited chances. I looked at the available choices and promised Mercedes I could arrange everything. She asked which thing I would leave undone.

'Nothing.' 'Then read it again.'

Porsche wanted to follow one person. Tank wanted to keep enough resources for what came next. Nobody was wrong, which was inconvenient for my preferred method of settling an argument loudly.

A casino host drifted over to admire my confidence. Shawna sent him away before he could convert it into a credit line.

I chose one modest action. The rest waited, still wanting something. Mercedes nodded at the consequence instead of congratulating me.

'Damn,' I said. 'It keeps the bill.' Tank leaned back. 'Welcome, my nigga, to the part of gambling they don't put on the chandelier.'

Aiden's verdict. Sit with these choices if limited resources make a story richer. My casino confidence cannot pay a space-station bill, despite the jacket suggesting otherwise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC first game. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1578650/>

P168 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Citizen Sleeper 2: Starward Vector

Edition considered: PC sequel

Travel with a crew through uncertain contracts, where imperfect dice and limited resources make shared needs and consequences part of the story.

What you do. Choose contracts, allocate dice, manage crew concerns and resources, and respond to stress and damaged dice as journeys develop.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Crew systems, stress, contracts and damaged dice add heavy tracking despite declared untimed play and adjustable difficulty.

Why it might click. The sequel expands the dice-driven roleplaying into travel, crew-building, and contracts across an asteroid belt. A battered ship can become a home, while temporary jobs bring distinct characters and risks. The appeal is making a future through relationships as well as careful decisions.

The full catch. The current Steam record declares adjustable difficulty and play without timed input. It also describes stress, damaged dice, and multi-cycle contracts: waiting for you is not the same as removing consequences. Inspect the actual difficulty choices before relying on them.

Try this first. Learn one contract's objective, available dice, and stress consequences before committing actions. Try a manageable early job and ask whether preparing with a crew adds pleasure or too many interconnected things to track.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ship Has Rejected My Penthouse Upgrade

I tried to name our imaginary ship The Aiden Experience. Tank asked whether passengers could request a refund before takeoff.

Citizen Sleeper 2 made the crew and the next contract feel connected in ways my grand name did not cover. Mercedes wanted to know who was coming aboard. Porsche wanted to know whether the job was worth the trouble.

'Nigga, we can do it.' 'That's not the question,' Shawna said.

I moved a champagne crate to demonstrate cargo capacity and discovered it was empty. The actual bottles were behind Rosa, who had correctly anticipated that my demonstration would become a voyage.

The game's damaged dice looked less like bad luck once somebody depended on the plan. I stopped talking long enough to read the options.

Tank tapped the empty crate. 'Captain, your luxury fleet got no engine.'

I sat on it. Shawna came over and fixed my collar. 'At least the seating works.' The Aiden Experience opened as a bench and received its first favourable review.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the crew story when imperfect tools and uncertain jobs sound compelling. My ship remains available as a bench until somebody supplies more than the captain's name.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2442460/>

P169 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disco Elysium - The Final Cut

Edition considered: PC Final Cut

Investigate through conversations and competing inner voices, with unusual characters, roleplaying choices and a darkly funny world giving the detective story depth.

What you do. Explore scenes, question people, read or hear dialogue and make choices shaped by the detective's different skills and impulses.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Extensive dialogue, skill checks and inventory/character menus add substantial work; not every interaction is verified as untimed or hold-free.

Why it might click. The Final Cut presents a dense, voiced detective roleplaying story about a damaged investigator and a politically complicated city. Skills become argumentative inner voices, making character-building part of the writing. Conversations can be funny, cruel, revealing, and unexpectedly tender.

The full catch. Expect extensive dialogue, skill checks, inventory and character menus, and mature material including addiction and violence. A failed choice can have consequences. The manually checked source confirms the Final Cut edition, but does not certify all interactions as untimed or hold-free.

Try this first. Follow an early conversation and inspect one relevant skill explanation. Decide whether the competing voices delight you or interrupt the person you want to hear. Treat the opening as a test of tone as much as controls.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Necktie Has Demanded Its Own Room

I loosened my tie and told the room it had seen things. Tank said the room had seen me miss the same trouser pocket twice and could therefore confirm part of the testimony.

Disco Elysium put a detective's competing impulses in front of us. I recognised the sensation of several confident voices suggesting terrible plans. Shawna said those were usually just my friends warning me.

'Nigga, this tie understands complexity.' Mercedes lifted it off the table. 'This tie understands spilled rum.'

At the far bar, the cocaine guest had returned long enough to announce another business revelation. Porsche pointed him back toward the host. We already had enough unreliable narrators indoors.

I read the next exchange. Funny, ugly, human. My own joke went quiet halfway out.

Shawna touched my wrist. 'You want to keep going?' I nodded.

Tank took the tie before I could put it back on. 'Detective, evidence says this motherfucker needs laundry, not a promotion.'

Aiden's verdict. Enter for the voices, contradictions and difficult people if that darkness appeals. My necktie may testify, but its room-service charges remain entirely my responsibility.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app632470 on 2026-09-20, exact title Disco Elysium - The Final Cut. Source supports full English voice acting, skills, roleplaying choices, and mature content. Control and workload judgments remain editorial.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/632470/>

P170 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

NORCO

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a family mystery in a distinctive industrial landscape, where conversations, local detail and strange events make the place itself compelling to explore.

What you do. Explore scenes, talk to characters, inspect clues and work through the story's puzzles and other interactive sequences.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense themes and puzzles add work, and the source mentions fights; do not assume it is exclusively quiet dialogue.

Why it might click. NORCO combines a missing-person search with family history, industrial landscapes, and increasingly strange science fiction in South Louisiana. Its dialogue-focused point-and-click structure invites attention to both particular characters and the forces shaping their world.

The full catch. The official description also mentions puzzles and fights; do not treat dialogue-focused as proof that every sequence is mechanically quiet. Expect dense imagery, unfamiliar connections, and bereavement. Check each new interaction type and the text/interface size.

Try this first. Explore an early location and follow one clue about the missing brother. Pause to decide whether the place feels intriguing in its own right. Inspect the first unfamiliar mechanical sequence before assuming later play matches the opening.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P170 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

NORCO

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The South Has Sent My Mood Board Back

I had arranged a tray of objects to explain NORCO's atmosphere: a motel key, a plastic monkey, a broken sign and my most thoughtful sunglasses. Mercedes picked up the monkey.

'Nigga, did you read anything before decorating?' 'I communicate visually.' 'You communicate expensively.'

The game's family mystery and industrial landscape wanted attention more serious than my styling. Shawna read the first exchange without supplying a mood. I sat beside her.

Downstairs, the casino's enormous neon crown kept buzzing. Tank pulled our curtain halfway closed. The room looked better with less of my chosen view in it.

I tried to put the sunglasses on the monkey. Rosa took both and set down the food. 'Let something in here be useful.'

A detail on the screen caught Mercedes. She asked us to wait. We did.

The tray remained on the floor by my shoes, all its objects looking suddenly ordinary. Nigga, the actual place had arrived, and my expensive explanation had nothing left to say.

Aiden's verdict. Visit for a particular family and place, if their unease draws you in. My decorative monkey is not qualified to brief anyone on the American South.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1221250/>

My Wife Paused Me Without Touching the Controller

I had developed a theory about every person on the screen. This surprised nobody. I had also developed a theory about the waiter, the piano tuner and the woman who had asked whether the ice machine was down the hall.

Shawna waited until I finished explaining a character's entire life from one line of dialogue. Then she picked up the controller.

'Nigga, you want to know what she says next?' 'I know what she means.' 'You know what you mean. You've been telling the room for six minutes.'

Tank glanced over from the bar. 'That's the short version.'

I reached for my drink and discovered Rosa had moved it away from the electronics. She had left it within reach of my actual hand. A considerate correction, which is the most difficult kind to turn into an argument.

On the screen, a conversation waited. Across the room, Mercedes and Porsche were having one that did not.

'You told him I was performing again?' Mercedes asked. Porsche lowered a phone. 'He said the casino wanted an encore.' 'The casino got the song. I wanted the rest of the night.'

I started to step in. Shawna put her hand on my knee.

'Don't.' 'Baby, I can smooth this out.' 'You can make it about your ability to smooth things out. Different service.'

I stayed.

Porsche looked at the little stage. She had arranged the lights herself, argued the sound into behaving and thought an encore would be a compliment. Mercedes had spent the evening making sure the room heard the song instead of a story about the song. They wanted different endings to the same successful thing.

'I should've asked,' Porsche said. Mercedes nodded. 'Yeah.'

No smashed glass. No elaborate punishment. Two grown women adjusting a plan while I sat there with an entire unused entrance.

Tank came over carrying the microphone. 'They handed this to me.' 'What for?' 'To announce you were about to say something.' 'Nigga, I wasn't.'

He looked at Shawna. She shook her head. He put the microphone down so carefully it might have been a sleeping animal.

'Damn,' he said. 'Almost had an event.'

The screen conversation was still there. I read the next line. My magnificent interpretation developed a hole.

Shawna watched my face. 'What?' 'Nothing.' 'That was an expensive-looking nothing.'

The character had wanted something simpler than my theory allowed. I had supplied a motive, a secret and a childhood grievance where the actual words supplied one disappointed friend.

Nigga, I had furnished a whole house nobody asked to live in.

I let Shawna answer. She did not pick the line I would have picked. The story went somewhere interesting. I managed not to announce that this too had been contained within my analysis.

Rosa sat on the arm of Tank's chair. 'You two enjoying yourselves?' 'I am,' Shawna said. 'He's adjusting.'

My brother lifted his glass. 'To adjustment.' 'Nigga, don't toast my correction.'

Everybody drank anyway.

The piano tuner returned the spare key at last. He apologised for the confusion. Shawna took it and slipped it into her bag. I said our bedroom was now available for its intended purpose.

'Sleep?' Tank asked. 'Nigga, mind your marriage.'

Rosa smiled at him. 'You should.'

He stood so fast I thought the couch had caught fire.

They did not leave immediately. Rosa still wanted dessert. Tank sat back down, accepted a plate and looked at her with the patience of a man who understood that the evening was not improved by hurrying the part she was enjoying.

I took the lesson without volunteering that I had taken it.

On the screen, somebody started another difficult sentence. I kept my mouth shut long enough to hear the end.

P171 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kentucky Route Zero

Edition considered: PC complete five-act edition

Follow an unusual theatrical journey where conversations, working lives and strange places matter as much as finding out what happens next.

What you do. Explore scenes, choose conversation responses and follow the people met along a mysterious delivery route.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Expect substantial reading and ambiguity; the existing source does not certify every timing or held-input demand.

Why it might click. This five-act magical-realist adventure follows a delivery into a world of strange roads, precarious work, debts, and fragile communities. Its pleasure lies in language, staging, music, and atmosphere. Choices can feel like shaping a performance rather than selecting the correct solution to a puzzle.

The full catch. Expect substantial reading, ambiguity, and a pace that may feel deliberately indirect. The PC Edition has been manually matched to the assigned complete game. Check movement and text advance; no inspected source establishes every scene as free of held or timed input.

Try this first. Stay with one early encounter rather than trying to solve the whole world's meaning. Notice whether choosing a line makes you feel involved. If the theatrical distance leaves you cold, that is useful taste information, not a reading failure.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Highway Leads to a Room I Didn't Book

I asked the concierge for directions to somewhere impossible. He checked my room bill and said I had already arrived.

Kentucky Route Zero had made the familiar feel strange without raising its voice. Mercedes wanted to follow the conversation. I wanted to explain what everything represented. Shawna gave me a look that could close a conference.

'Nigga, it can mean something before you name it.'

Tank pushed aside the curtain. From our floor, the casino road disappeared underneath the hotel and came out somewhere else. Rosa said that was where the valet had taken her car three hours ago.

The game's delivery felt like a journey with people who had their own reasons to keep moving. I stopped trying to make a map of everybody's meaning.

Mercedes read another line. The piano below us answered with a chord somebody was testing. For once, two unrelated things were allowed to sound good together.

I rang the concierge. 'Forget the directions.' 'Which ones, sir?' Nigga had a fair question.

Aiden's verdict. Take this road for its people, theatre and strange atmosphere. The concierge cannot guarantee a destination, especially when the nigga requesting directions is asking metaphorically.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app231200, Kentucky Route Zero: PC Edition; the five-act PC edition matches this assigned game despite title-review flag. Other control and mood judgments remain provisional.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/231200/>

P172 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Night in the Woods

Edition considered: PC release

Revisit friendships in a changing hometown, where funny conversations and ordinary outings lead into a more unsettling story about belonging.

What you do. Move through town, talk with friends, explore familiar places and take part in activities along the story.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Movement includes platforming and other active sequences; a strong character story does not remove those control demands.

Why it might click. Night in the Woods offers the company of young adults negotiating friendship, disappointment, work, and changes in their hometown. Its animal characters carry recognizably human conversations, with a mystery growing around the edges of daily wandering.

The full catch. Movement and platforming are part of its adventure structure, and additional activity types require checking. Do not file it as a static visual novel. Its themes can be bleak, including economic decline and emotional distress, despite the bright designs and frequent jokes.

Try this first. Walk through an early stretch of town and talk to somebody who knows Mae. Test the movement before investing in the story. Decide whether the everyday conversations are reward enough for the amount of traversal between them.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Came Home with a Band and Nobody Rehearsed

I told the hotel pianist we were starting a band. Tank said he had come upstairs to eat. I said every great drummer began with objections.

Night in the Woods brought us back to old friends and a place that had kept changing without permission. I began listing everybody who had missed me last time I left Vegas.

'Nigga, the valet missed your tip,' Porsche said. 'That's affection with an invoice.'

Mercedes picked up a spare guitar and tested one string. She wanted a song. Shawna wanted me to hear the awkward conversation on the screen before I made the homecoming about applause.

I sat down. Somebody in the game said something that sounded funny until it didn't. Tank quit tapping his fork against the glass.

'That's your part,' Mercedes told him. 'The silence.'

He nodded. I reached for the microphone. Five people looked at me at once. Nigga, the band had found unity before we had found a name.

Aiden's verdict. Come for the friendships and the uneasy business of returning home. My new band accepts silence as a contribution and has therefore become dangerously good.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/481510/>

P173 / A PLACE TO START

Beacon Pines

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a branching storybook mystery where discovering and choosing particular words can change what happens to its characters in meaningful ways.

What you do. Move through the setting, talk to characters, collect useful words and try them at branching moments.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Branch tracking and creepy events remain despite untimed-play declarations; test walking and menu selection for held-input demands.

Why it might click. Beacon Pines combines exploring a small town with collecting word charms and revisiting branches through a story tree. New words can transform a moment and open different events. Curiosity about how a sentence changes the world becomes part of solving its mystery.

The full catch. The Steam record declares play without timed input and keyboard-only operation. Branch tracking still adds a memory burden, and the cute art accompanies creepy events. Those declarations do not establish that every control avoids holds; test ordinary walking and menu selection.

Try this first. Collect an early charm and use it at a turning point. Then inspect how the story tree represents the route. Continue if comparing possibilities feels like discovery rather than keeping several unfinished stories in your head.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Word Was Charming Until I Put Myself in It

I wrote AIDEN beside three words on a hotel napkin: AVAILABLE, SPECTACULAR and LATE. Shawna slid the first two away.

Beacon Pines let words change the direction of a story. I appreciated that. I had spent years trying to make late sound like an entrance.

Tank read the napkin. 'Nigga, available to who?' 'The evening.' 'The evening already ate.'

Mercedes wanted to try a different branch. Porsche leaned across her shoulder and pointed at one word. They argued about what it might do, then Mercedes chose for herself.

I added MISUNDERSTOOD to my little autobiography. Rosa put a plate on top of it. The word disappeared beneath potatoes, a development I considered hostile to literature.

The game showed us a new possibility. Shawna smiled at the sentence rather than at me. I found I wanted to see the next one too.

I left the napkin under the plate. My wife touched my knee. 'Look at you, baby. Finally on time for something.'

Aiden's verdict. Open it when a single word changing a story sounds inviting. My napkin autobiography remains available, although the potatoes have won editorial control of the ending.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1269640/>

P174 / A PLACE TO START

Mutazione

Edition considered: PC release

Spend time in an unusual community through conversations and gardening, with music helping give the people and their surroundings a distinctive mood.

What you do. Explore the community, speak with residents and tend gardens as their interconnected stories develop around you.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Illness, family secrets and community conflict matter; verify the declared untimed, input and saving options on the installed version.

Why it might click. Mutazione follows Kai visiting her grandfather in an unusual island community. Conversations, old tensions, and musical gardens sit alongside the supernatural plot. Its attraction is spending enough time with a place that the relationships begin to matter.

The full catch. Illness, family secrets, and community conflict are central; gentle presentation is not a promise of emotionally light material. Steam declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and save-anytime. Verify those options on the installed version and inspect ordinary navigation.

Try this first. Meet one resident and spend time with an early garden interaction. Judge the balance between conversation and moving through the community. If you like it, a note of the next person to visit may make returning easier.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Garden Grows Better When I Stop Singing at It

I stood over a hotel fern and sang what I considered a nourishing note. Tank watched one leaf sag. 'Nigga, that plant just requested checkout.'

Mutazione had gardens, music and people whose lives were tangled together. Mercedes listened to the sound while Rosa leaned closer to a conversation. Neither wanted my botanical solo.

Shawna took the watering jug from me. 'It's artificial.' 'Then explain the attitude.'

At the bar, Porsche was refusing another guest's request for Mercedes to perform. Mercedes heard the refusal and kept playing. A small kindness, delivered without making her turn around.

I sat beside Rosa and asked what the character had said. She repeated it. I listened instead of looking for an entrance.

The fern remained fake. The little world on the screen felt considerably less so.

Tank put the plant on the far side of the room. 'Better acoustics over there.' 'For who?' 'Nigga, everybody still alive enough to object.'

Aiden's verdict. Visit for community, conversation and the pleasure of growing a garden. The hotel fern has relocated permanently, citing unresolved artistic differences with my voice.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1080750/>

P175 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wytchwood

Edition considered: PC release

Gather strange ingredients and craft useful things while a witch's errands lead through an illustrated world of stories, creatures and connected tasks.

What you do. Explore locations, collect ingredients, follow recipes and return with crafted items to advance different characters' requests.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Nested recipes, repeated travel and monsters add work; keeping several ingredient chains in mind can become demanding.

Why it might click. Wytchwood turns gothic fairy-tale errands into gathering and crafting. The witch's judgments give the recipes personality: ingredients are steps toward changing a troublesome situation, not simply collecting for its own sake. The illustrated world helps make each place distinctive.

The full catch. Expect repeated travel, nested recipes, and remembering where resources come from. The official description includes monsters and overcoming them through tools and spells; do not assume that crafting removes all hazards or movement demands. Check inventory and held movement.

Try this first. Follow one early recipe from request to ingredients to use. Notice whether retracing a route is satisfying familiarity or unwanted repetition. The useful trial is the whole small crafting loop, not just admiring the art.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Recipe Needs One Ingredient I Have Never Heard Of

I promised Rosa I could improve the party punch with something from the hotel garden. She caught my wrist before my confidence became a beverage.

'Nigga, that is landscaping.' 'It's fragrant.' 'So is floor cleaner.'

Wytchwood had a better reason to gather odd ingredients: a whole chain of tasks leading into stories. I liked the witch's authority. Tank liked watching me discover that authority still had errands.

Mercedes read a recipe and asked where the next item might be. I pointed at a distant place with the certainty of a man who had not checked his pockets.

Shawna opened the inventory. The item was already there.

'Baby,' she said, 'you just sent everybody across the room for your own hand.'

Rosa took the punch bowl away from me. I followed the actual game instead. It turned out that remembering what I had was an excellent first step toward finding what I needed. Nigga, several hotel purchases could have benefited from that discovery.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the witch's errands if gathering and making things sound satisfying. My punch improvement has been cancelled until I can distinguish a recipe from landscaping.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/729000/>

P176 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Wandersong

Edition considered: PC release

Meet a colourful world through a bard's singing, with music and character encounters giving an active adventure its playful and emotional shape.

What you do. Move through scenes, sing to interact with the world and handle platforming as the adventure continues.

Mixed controls | Action continues while you think | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. This is an active platforming detour; warm music and artwork do not remove real-time movement and reaction demands.

Why it might click. Wandersong builds a characterful adventure around a bard who changes things through music. Its humor, unusual interactions, and emotional story can make singing feel like a way of meeting the world. The official pitch also explicitly calls it a platforming adventure.

The full catch. Directional movement, platforming, and selecting musical responses are meaningful demands. The developer's broad accessibility language about color and sound does not answer every motor-input question. This is a contrasting option for someone who wants those active elements, not a guaranteed quiet story.

Try this first. Try an early singing interaction and a small piece of traversal. Check whether choosing the notes and moving through the space are enjoyable. If either feels like an obstacle, keep the musical premise separate from the actual fit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Karaoke Machine Has Requested a Better Singer

I announced that the power of song could solve anything. Mercedes looked at the karaoke machine. 'Start with whatever the fuck you did to its settings.'

Wandersong gave a bard a world to meet through music. I gave the penthouse one long note that made Tank inspect the ceiling.

'Nigga, is that you or the fire system?' 'That's range.' 'Then leave it at a distance.'

Shawna wanted to hear the actual song. Porsche lowered my microphone until it pointed at my shoes, which were better at keeping rhythm than the rest of me.

The game kept moving. Singing belonged to an active adventure, and I watched the little character negotiate what my grand theory had treated as automatic.

Mercedes sang a phrase softly from her seat. The room listened. I knew when to join her this time.

I didn't. She finished, smiled, and handed me a glass. Nigga, supporting a performance could feel surprisingly good when I stopped trying to stand in its middle.

Aiden's verdict. Take the musical adventure when singing and active movement both appeal. My microphone faces the carpet until the hotel confirms which sound triggered its concern.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/530320/>

P177 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Chicory: A Colorful Tale

Edition considered: PC release

Paint and explore a world where colour, creativity and a character's personal story develop together, with an optional second person helping paint.

What you do. Move through the world, colour scenes, solve obstacles and try the different available painting roles with a companion.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Painting, movement and active sequences need checking, and the two cooperative roles do not offer identical control.

Why it might click. Chicory is a coloring-book adventure about taking up an artist's brush. Painting changes the environment and supports puzzles, while the story explores creativity and the people around it. The official listing explicitly includes local cooperative painting.

The full catch. Painting, directional movement, and more active sequences need separate checks. Local co-op does not necessarily give both people identical roles. Inspect brush behavior and the game's actual options before deciding whether the action is welcome; no assumed setting is required by this card.

Try this first. Color one small area and use paint for an early puzzle. If playing together, establish who controls movement and who paints. The point is to discover whether making marks feels playful without turning the result into an art assessment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / She Painted Over My Name and Improved the Landscape

I painted AIDEN across the hotel's practice canvas. Mercedes looked at the size of it. 'Nigga, what happened to the picture?' 'It acquired a subject.'

Chicory gave us a world to colour. Shawna wanted a patch of blue. I said I could supply a particularly distinguished shade. Tank told me the Crips had survived this long without my paint consultancy.

My wife took the brush. I kept pointing to places that needed my initials. She painted a beautiful little shape straight over the largest one.

'Baby.' 'Yes?' 'That was my signature.' 'Now it's a pond.'

Porsche moved closer to see. Rosa said she liked the pond. The room had reached a consensus with insulting speed.

We tried the game's different jobs together. I asked what Shawna wanted me to do before announcing what I intended.

She smiled. 'There. That colour.' I followed her lead. Nigga, somehow the world got brighter while my name got smaller.

Aiden's verdict. Bring it when making colour together sounds joyful and the actions suit both players. The pond remains unsigned, which has improved its reputation among actual visitors.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1123450/>

P178 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Rakuen

Edition considered: PC release

A hospital story opens into a fantastical world, connecting exploration and puzzles with the lives and feelings of people encountered along the way.

What you do. Guide the character through scenes, speak with people, explore the storybook world and solve puzzles that connect their stories.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Illness and grief are central, while non-combat play still includes movement, navigation and puzzle demands that need checking.

Why it might click. Rakuen follows a boy and his mother as helping people in a fantasy world reveals the lives of people around him. Music and character stories connect the two settings. The developer explicitly describes a non-combat adventure with puzzles and dialogue-based mysteries.

The full catch. Hospital life, illness, grief, and unfinished relationships are central themes. Non-combat does not mean no navigation or difficult puzzle. Check walking, object interaction, text advance, and any eerie sections; decide separately whether the emotional subject is welcome.

Try this first. Explore a small early area and speak with one person. Test the ordinary movement and the way information is presented. Continue for interest in the people, with permission to stop before an emotional scene feels like an obligation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hospital Story Made Me Put Down the Microphone

I tried to introduce Rakuen like a headline attraction. Shawna took the microphone out of my hand before I found a voice large enough to spoil it.

A child in a hospital and a storybook world deserved more than my best impression of importance. Rosa settled on the sofa. Tank sat beside her without bringing the joke he had been carrying from the bar.

I lowered the room's music. Mercedes noticed and nodded once. No applause. Nigga, apparently a useful action could arrive without an audience.

The game let another kind of place open beside a difficult one. Porsche wanted to follow the people. Shawna kept her hand in mine.

I almost said something reassuring I had no right to promise. My wife squeezed my fingers, and the sentence stayed where it belonged.

We watched a little longer. When Rosa asked to stop, Tank reached for the water before anyone asked why.

I put the microphone in its case. This story could speak without me turning up the volume.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the storybook only if its hospital setting and grief are welcome tonight. The microphone stays closed; this invitation does not require an uplifting speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/559210/>

P179 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

To the Moon

Edition considered: PC original release

Follow a person's memories toward a final wish, discovering how small details change the meaning of an emotionally focused story over time.

What you do. Explore scenes from a life, examine important objects and follow conversations that gradually connect the memories.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Bereavement and emotional revelations matter; non-combat storytelling still leaves movement and particular interaction sequences to check.

Why it might click. To the Moon follows two doctors working backward through a dying man's memories to understand and fulfill his final wish. Its compact story links small details across a life. Music and changing context supply much of the emotional effect.

The full catch. The developer describes a non-combat experience, but movement, searching for objects, and puzzle interfaces remain. Bereavement and questions about memory and relationships carry significant emotional weight. Verify text advance and the particular PC version rather than assuming all ports behave alike.

Try this first. Play through an early memory investigation, noticing whether gathering its clues supports your curiosity. There is no need to solve the eventual meaning in advance. Check whether the dialogue rhythm and movement let the story land comfortably.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Moon Has Declined to Explain My Marriage

I said that if somebody walked through my memories, they would find romance, courage and exceptional tailoring. Shawna said they would also find the afternoon I locked both keys in the car. To the Moon asked us to follow a life toward a wish. Tank wanted to know why the wish mattered. I wanted to claim I already understood.

'Nigga, you barely understand why Rosa moved the chairs,' Mercedes said.

Rosa looked up. 'People wanted to sit together.' The explanation was so simple I briefly resented it. On the screen, an ordinary detail changed the shape of what came before. Shawna leaned forward. I let her finish reading before talking.

'Would you change anything?' I whispered. 'About you?' 'About us.'

She looked at the room, then at my hand around hers. 'I'd keep the spare key.' I laughed quietly. The moon could keep its grand answer. Nigga, my wife had found a small one with evidence.

Aiden's verdict. Choose this memory story when the reason behind a wish sounds compelling. My marriage retains its mysteries, but the spare car key has solved one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC original release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/206440/>

P180 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Finding Paradise

Edition considered: PC release

Discover a life through memories and conflicting wishes, with a standalone story that gives its character's contradictions room to matter and develop.

What you do. Explore remembered scenes, examine significant objects and follow conversations that reveal the circumstances behind a difficult wish.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Reading, walking and details that matter later require attention, while end-of-life material remains central to the story.

Why it might click. Finding Paradise is a standalone follow-up in the memory-traversing series. The doctors investigate Colin's life and a wish whose apparent contradictions invite a closer look. It offers another character-centered story about how a life can mean more than its neatest explanation.

The full catch. Expect reading, walking, and attention to details that gain significance later. End-of-life material remains central. The publisher says previous games are not required, but that does not establish identical controls or a complete absence of unusual sequences.

Try this first. Follow the first substantial memory scene and identify one question you want answered. Check ordinary movement and dialogue handling. Let the uncertainty be part of the pleasure rather than trying to create a complete timeline immediately.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Perfect Life Has Two Mutually Exclusive Endings

I told Shawna my perfect life involved excitement, peace, endless travel and never having to pack. Tank looked at me. 'Nigga, you want a hotel to follow you.'

Finding Paradise put a complicated wish in front of us. Mercedes wanted to know how the pieces fitted. I announced that people simply needed to decide what they wanted.

My wife raised one eyebrow. It was the expensive eyebrow. The one that knew where all my contradictory promises were buried.

'You wanted a quiet night,' she said. 'And a band.' 'A small band.' 'Nigga, there's a trumpet in our bathroom.'

I went and let the musician out. He had only been looking for somewhere to practise, which somehow made my life less defensible.

The game kept its person's contradictions. They made him more interesting than my tidy explanation would have.

I sat beside Shawna and stopped trying to repair the premise. Peace arrived for almost a whole conversation. The trumpet respected the closed door.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when a life that refuses a tidy explanation sounds worth hearing. My travelling hotel remains unbuilt, and the bathroom has been returned to civilian use.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/337340/>

P181 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Impostor Factory

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a strange murder-and-memory story in which familiar situations twist into something unexpected, with a standalone narrative and unsettling comic touches throughout.

What you do. Explore scenes, examine objects and follow conversations as the story rearranges what familiar events appear to mean.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Its time-loop premise does not establish actual timer behavior; movement, interaction sequences and disturbing material still need checking.

Why it might click. Impostor Factory begins with a strange party and a time-loop murder mystery, then develops into a broader narrative. Its mixture of absurd comedy and emotional storytelling makes it a candidate for someone who enjoys being led somewhere they did not initially expect.

The full catch. The publisher permits independent play but notes that series order affects the experience. Expect reading, walking, deaths, and disturbing imagery within the mystery. The time-loop premise does not itself verify the absence of timed tasks or unfamiliar input sequences.

Try this first. Follow the opening invitation and inspect an early area without looking up the eventual explanation. Check movement and dialogue handling. Decide whether the strange humor earns your trust before committing to the story's later changes of direction.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bathroom Has Seen Me Before

I came out of the bathroom and found Tank holding the same shrimp I had watched him eat a minute earlier. I pointed at it. 'Nigga, explain time.'

He held up the plate. 'They brought more.'

Impostor Factory had made me suspicious of an ordinary room. Shawna asked whether I was ready to continue. I told her we needed to establish that the bathroom was not repeating itself.

'You left your phone in there twice,' she said. 'That's you repeating yourself.'

Mercedes followed the strange story while I inspected the door. Porsche walked past me, retrieved my phone and handed it over without slowing down.

The game turned the familiar wrong in a way my little investigation had not managed. I sat down before the next surprise.

Tank offered me a shrimp. I took it. Same taste, new shrimp. Nigga, science was willing to proceed. Shawna kept the phone, which solved the part of the mystery we actually controlled.

Aiden's verdict. Enter when a familiar room becoming deeply strange sounds entertaining. My bathroom investigation is closed, and the shrimp supply has been cleared of temporal misconduct.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182620/>

P182 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

A Bird Story

Edition considered: PC release

A short, largely wordless story uses animation and small interactions to follow a boy and a bird through an imaginative, emotional experience.

What you do. Guide the character through brief scenes and follow the changing relationship through gestures, movement and visual events.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Little reading does not remove movement or input checks; this is a compact interactive story rather than a complex mystery.

Why it might click. A Bird Story is a short, wordless interactive animation about a boy and an injured bird. Its small scale and reliance on images make it distinct from the more dialogue-heavy games nearby. The developer explicitly presents it as an experiment, not To the Moon's sequel.

The full catch. Fewer words do not eliminate movement, interaction, or waiting through a deliberately authored sequence. The child-and-bird story still has emotional stakes. Check the ordinary controls and whether the amount of interaction matches what you want from a game tonight.

Try this first. Follow the first simple routine and observe how images communicate the relationship. Let the initial section show you its rhythm. If you want many decisions or extensive dialogue, use that preference to choose another page rather than forcing this one.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bird Was Not Booked to Sing Backup

A little bird landed on the penthouse balcony. I approached with the kind of smile I usually reserved for photographers. Tank watched from the sofa. 'Nigga, don't offer it a contract.'

A Bird Story was already playing inside. Very little dialogue. I considered adding some context. Mercedes reached for the volume and found, to her delight, no setting that increased me.

The actual bird hopped sideways. I explained that I respected its creative process. Shawna put a hand on my shoulder and pulled me back from the glass.

'It wants the balcony, baby. Not a meeting.'

We watched the screen's small story unfold. Rosa rested her feet on Tank's lap. He adjusted without making a speech about the labour.

The real bird stayed another moment, then flew off. I opened my mouth.

'Don't,' Porsche said. 'It wasn't a metaphor about your freedom.'

Nigga, some nights a man cannot even lose a bird without being edited.

Aiden's verdict. Try the small wordless story when gesture and atmosphere sound sufficient. The balcony bird has declined representation and will not be appearing on my next album.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/327410/>

P183 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers

Edition considered: PC release

Gather and build toward a meaningful farewell in a world shaped by loss, with exploration and crafting supporting the emotional story.

What you do. Travel through locations, gather materials, craft what is needed and follow the characters working toward their shared purpose.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Gathering and travel add practical work, while plague, bereavement and grief make the story emotionally demanding despite its gentle appearance.

Why it might click. Rocket of Whispers connects exploring a ruined snowy world with building a rocket to honor the dead. Objects found along the way reveal history as well as supplying materials. The gathering has an emotional purpose shared by the surviving characters.

The full catch. Expect travel, searching, equipment crafting, and keeping track of needed supplies. Plague aftermath, loss, and saying goodbye are central. The store's single-player description is explicit; two protagonists do not imply two-player control. Check navigation and repeated collection demands.

Try this first. Explore an early area and bring back one useful material or discovered story. Notice whether the search feels purposeful or repetitive. A strong emotional premise need not compensate for a gathering loop you do not enjoy.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rocket Is Not for My Grand Entrance

I said the rocket ought to have my name on it. Mercedes looked at the screen, then at me. 'Nigga, hear what it's for first.'

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers gave us a reason to build that was larger and sadder than arrival. Rosa sat forward. Tank stopped playing with the hotel matchbook.

I had been imagining fireworks over the casino. The story was imagining how to say goodbye. My splendid launch announcement suddenly had no useful place to go.

Shawna took the little model rocket out of my hand. 'You can help without getting on it.'

We followed the work. Gathering, making, keeping a purpose alive while the world carried loss around it. Mercedes asked to read the next part herself.

I nodded and moved the model away from the drinks. That was all. No joke to rescue my entrance.

Later, Tank asked whether I still wanted the name painted on the rocket. 'No,' I said. He put down the pen. Nigga understood.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when work, grief and a purpose worth carrying sound welcome. My name has been removed from the rocket so its actual reason can remain visible.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/742250/>

P184 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

Edition considered: PC Full Bloom Edition

Travel through an emotional science-fiction story where mysterious songs, remembered relationships and exploration give the journey its distinctive sense of longing and discovery.

What you do. Read conversations, explore locations, manage journey resources and work through light puzzles connected to the characters' search.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The voiced edition uses Japanese or Chinese audio with English text; resource choices and reading still need attention.

Why it might click. Full Bloom presents a voiced, visual-novel-style space adventure following Jun and Eda in search of mysterious starsongs. Their journey connects personal motives with conflict, ancient places, and other travelers. Music and the relationship between the leads are central attractions.

The full catch. The official page describes light puzzles and resource management alongside narrative scenes. English subtitles/interface are listed, while the checked full-audio languages are Japanese and Chinese. Check reading, exploration, and sound-puzzle presentation; the word accessible in marketing is not a complete control audit.

Try this first. Follow an early exchange, then inspect one exploration or travel decision. Confirm language settings and whether the sound-related information is presented in a usable way. Continue if the relationship interests you as much as the scenery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P184 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Love Song Has Failed the Airlock

I sang three notes at the hotel balcony and announced that the stars had heard me. Tank shut the door. 'Nigga, the neighbours heard you. Different audience.'

Echo of Starsong had a much better use for a voice in the dark. Mercedes listened closely. Porsche leaned against her chair, finally still.

I tried to translate the feeling into a grand romantic speech for Shawna. She touched my mouth with two fingers.

'You could just sit with me.' 'Baby, I'm offering the cosmos.' 'The cosmos has chairs.'

We sat. The game moved through a world where a sound could carry more than my explanation of it. I watched Mercedes replay a little moment because she wanted to hear how it landed.

The hotel pianist began another song outside. Tank closed the inner door this time, gently.

I kept my promise and said nothing. Shawna rested against me. Nigga, somehow I had offered less and ended up closer to what I wanted.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the journey when voice, memory and a strange universe draw you in. My balcony performance remains grounded until the neighbours withdraw their complaint.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually opened Steam app1504500 and verified exact Full Bloom Edition title, voice-language table, narrative/exploration/light puzzle/resource description. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1504500/>

P185 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist

Edition considered: PC release

Shape a life in a science-fiction colony, where relationships, remembered experiences and card-based decisions develop across years with consequences for the surrounding community.

What you do. Choose activities, build relationships, use experience cards and make decisions as the character grows within the colony.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Cards, skills, schedules and branching relationships require heavy tracking; the attractive setting also includes danger, death and difficult personal material.

Why it might click. This narrative roleplaying game follows ten formative years in an alien colony. Experiences become cards used in challenges, while activities and relationships influence the future. Its appeal is watching personal growth and a larger community's fate affect one another.

The full catch. Cards, skills, schedules, and branching relationships create substantial system and memory demands. The attractive watercolor setting includes danger, death, and difficult personal material. Inspect challenge rules and content information rather than treating a youthful cast as proof of lightness.

Try this first. Choose an early activity and learn one card challenge deliberately. Pay attention to a character whose company you enjoy. Decide whether the cards make your history feel meaningful or add a management layer you would prefer to avoid.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Childhood Has Refused the Rematch

I told Tank that if I could grow up again, I would make every correct decision. He looked at the jacket I had chosen that morning. 'Nigga, you still got time tonight.'

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist let years gather into experiences and choices. I wanted to optimise the whole life before meeting anybody in it.

Mercedes asked which friend I cared about. I pointed at the numbers. She waited. The numbers did not introduce themselves.

Shawna sat across from me and picked up one of the hotel playing cards. 'What did you learn the year we met?' 'That destiny recognised me.' 'Try again.'

Rosa laughed. Tank hid his face behind his drink, badly.

I looked at my wife. 'That somebody could hear all my bullshit and still ask what I meant.'

She smiled and set the card down. The game's next choice waited. Nigga, I was suddenly less interested in making a perfect life than in noticing who was there.

Aiden's verdict. Explore a changing life if cards, relationships and consequential choices sound absorbing. My childhood rematch has been postponed until I improve tonight's jacket selection.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1148760/>

P186 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Growing Up

Edition considered: PC release

Guide a life through interests, skills and school choices, with a nostalgic setting and everyday decisions gradually opening different possible futures for the character.

What you do. Choose activities, develop abilities, manage opportunities and take part in school-related tasks and minigames as time passes.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Numerous skills, planning decisions, exams and minigames can turn the life story into a substantial menu and tracking task.

Why it might click. Growing Up combines a coming-of-age story with choosing activities and developing skills. Friendships and family continuity give the schedules a narrative context, while its nineties setting offers a particular flavor of ordinary life and remembered ambitions.

The full catch. The primary description explicitly includes aptitude mini-games, exams, daily scheduling, many skills, and varied outcomes. This is a management-rich life game, not only dialogue. Check the mini-game inputs and whether balancing the systems feels enjoyable rather than like another planner.

Try this first. Set one early schedule, try its associated activity, and see how a friendship develops around it. Use the result to judge the management loop. There is no need to optimize a whole childhood before deciding whether you like playing one day.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hotel Has Lost My Perfect Childhood Schedule

I made a schedule for becoming an impressive adult. Mercedes read it. 'Nigga, you're already an adult.' 'Exactly. We have proof the method works.'

Growing Up put school, interests and changing opportunities in front of us. I looked at the available activities and began naming the ones I would have conquered.

Tank asked whether learning to pack had been available. Shawna asked whether listening counted as an elective. Rosa wanted to know why lunch was missing.

I told them greatness required sacrifice. Rosa put a plate in my hand. 'Start by sacrificing this conversation.'

The game kept a life moving through ordinary choices. I watched an interest develop and wondered what would happen if I followed it without turning it into a trophy.

Porsche found my schedule beneath a cushion. She had used the back to write a song title. It was the only part anybody wanted to keep.

Nigga, adulthood had produced mixed but extremely legible results.

Aiden's verdict. Try shaping a life when small interests becoming future possibilities sounds appealing. My perfect schedule is available on the reverse of a much better song.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1191120/>

P187 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Volcano Princess

Edition considered: PC release

Guide a young character's development through activities and relationships in a fantasy setting, seeing how many choices shape the life ahead of her.

What you do. Choose activities, develop skills, manage relationships and consider how different opportunities fit the character's growing interests and future.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Menus, statistics and many activities require planning; parental death and conflict accompany the development story, so inspect each activity's controls.

Why it might click. Volcano Princess mixes a fantasy coming-of-age story with arranging a daughter's activities, studies, and relationships. Different interests can lead toward different lives. The attraction is seeing a character develop through the choices and people around her.

The full catch. Menus, stats, planning, and multiple activity types are a substantial part of play. The story begins after a parent's death and includes conflict and combat-related training. Inspect each activity's controls and avoid treating the parenting premise as a simple conversation game.

Try this first. Choose one early activity and see how its result connects to a conversation or new opportunity. Check the calendar and character information together. Continue if guiding development is enjoyable without needing a supposedly perfect outcome.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Princess Has Chosen a Career I Didn't Announce

I told Shawna I would be an excellent royal parent. She looked around the suite I had filled with unnecessary lights. 'Nigga, you can barely raise the curtains.'

Volcano Princess asked what kind of life could emerge from activities, relationships and guidance. I immediately selected an imaginary crown big enough to explain my involvement.

Mercedes took it off me and put it on the lamp. The lamp looked calmer with authority than I did.

'What if she wants something else?' Rosa asked. 'Who?' 'The person whose life you're planning.'

Tank leaned forward. Nigga enjoyed a question with a visible target.

I watched the options without announcing the future. A choice could be interesting because it belonged to somebody, not because it made a fine speech for the parent.

Shawna turned off two of my extra lights. The room improved. 'See?' she said. 'You can support a future without being the brightest thing in it.' The lamp kept the crown.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the life-shaping fantasy if its many choices sound enjoyable. The crown stays on the lamp until I learn whose future the evening is discussing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1669980/>

P188 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Long Live The Queen

Edition considered: PC release

Plan a young ruler's education while dangerous events test what she has learned, making preparation and consequences the central attraction of the story.

What you do. Select lessons and activities, develop abilities and make story decisions whose outcomes depend on the skills already learned.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. This is a difficult planning detour with dangerous outcomes and death; substantial skill tracking matters more than the gentle-looking artwork.

Why it might click. Long Live The Queen makes preparation and choices the center of a perilous royal coming-of-age story. Learning which skills and decisions help the young heir survive can become a puzzle across attempts. It is an option for someone who actively enjoys that kind of consequence.

The full catch. The official premise emphasizes threats and survival. Skill planning, hidden consequences, and character death make this a deliberate detour rather than a low-pressure suggestion. Cute presentation does not soften the underlying challenge into a guaranteed easy evening.

Try this first. Inspect the training choices and follow an early consequence. Ask whether discovering how the system works is enjoyable even when an outcome goes badly. If avoiding punishing decisions is a hard preference, choose another story immediately.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Crown Fits but the Coronation Cake Is Suspicious

I borrowed the hotel magician's crown and said ruling looked comfortable. Tank examined the velvet cushion. 'Nigga, that's where they hide the rabbit.'

Long Live the Queen offered a harsher education. Choosing what to learn could become a question of surviving what came next. My promise to improvise began losing value immediately.

Mercedes asked which lesson I would take. I chose public speaking. Shawna laughed once. 'Of course this nigga wants a better last sentence.'

Rosa brought out the cake. I stared at it because the game had made royal hospitality feel complicated.

'It's chocolate,' she said. 'Can you establish that?' 'Eat it or don't. I'm not testifying.'

Tank took a slice while I hesitated. Nothing happened except pleasure.

I put the crown back on its cushion and read the game's choices more carefully. The magician came to collect it. 'How was being king?' 'Nigga, I need a tutor and a less imaginative caterer.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the difficult royal planning only if failure and preparation are part of the appeal. Rosa's chocolate cake has been cleared without a succession crisis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251990/>

P189 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Roadwarden

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a text-led journey through a difficult region, choosing routes and responses while supplies, time and encounters give the travel meaningful consequences.

What you do. Read locations and conversations, choose actions, manage supplies and decide which paths or duties to pursue on the journey.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Heavy reading, survival resources, health and limited in-game time add pressure; exact input timing remains unverified.

Why it might click. Roadwarden offers a richly written fantasy journey through settlements, roads, and uncertain loyalties. Its text-based roleplaying combines conversation, inventory problems, survival, and discoveries about a particular place. The pleasure is becoming familiar with a world through attentive decisions.

The full catch. The source explicitly mentions hit points, survival mechanics, and quests restricted by in-game time. Reading at your own pace does not remove that strategic pressure. Expect substantial text and several tracked resources; inspect any typed-response or menu operations.

Try this first. Reach an early conversation or travel choice and identify what it costs in the game's systems. Make one decision because you are curious about its result. Judge whether the prose and the management work well together for you.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Badge Does Not Open the Hotel's Back Door

I put on a badge and announced that no road was closed to me. Tank pointed at the service door. I pulled. It stayed shut.

Roadwarden gave a traveller duties, danger and limited resources. I gave the hotel staff a growing reason to ask why a man in evening clothes kept trying their door.

Shawna read the next passage. 'You could ask where it leads.' 'Baby, authority shouldn't have to ask.'

Rosa walked over, asked a waiter and learned it led to the bins. My authority had been passionately demanding rubbish access.

Mercedes wanted to follow one path in the game. Porsche wanted to know what it would cost us. We looked at the options instead of assuming the badge supplied an answer.

Tank clipped my badge onto the bread basket. 'This is protecting something worth having.'

I sat down and read. Nigga, the road got more interesting when I stopped pretending the title on my chest already knew where to go.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the text journey when routes, duties and difficult trade-offs sound rewarding. My badge now guards the bread, a post with excellent public support.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1155970/>

P190 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a life shaped by a rigid social order, with consequential choices about identity, loyalty and ambition giving the narrative its serious weight.

What you do. Read the character's developing life, choose responses and commitments, and follow how decisions alter relationships and possible futures.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense reading and long-term planning accompany oppression, death and costly consequences; this is a deliberately heavy narrative option.

Why it might click. This narrative roleplaying game follows a life within a harsh fantasy empire. Decisions, learned traits, family ties, and social position shape possible paths. It offers the pleasure of tracing how personal ambitions interact with an unjust and powerful order.

The full catch. The publisher calls it a hardcore narrative RPG and emphasizes costly consequences, oppression, death, and rebirth. Dense reading and long-term planning are central burdens. Treat it as a deliberate heavy-story option, not a gentle alternative simply because much of the action is written.

Try this first. Read an early chapter and inspect how one decision changes a relationship or trait. Decide whether you want to inhabit this society's pressures. You can value the writing without accepting the emotional weight of a full life inside it.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Noble Birth Has Been Questioned by Room Service

I told the waiter I came from greatness. He asked which room. I said the question was larger than that. Nigga waited with the tray until I supplied a number.

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante placed a life inside a hard social order. I began imagining how effortlessly I would rise above it.

Shawna looked at the waiter still holding my breakfast. 'Start by letting him put that down.'

I moved. Mercedes read the next choice and stopped smiling. The story had consequences no amount of my cheerful self-description could erase.

Tank asked what I would give up. I said the system ought to change. 'Sure, my nigga. What do you choose right now?'

Rosa pulled a chair closer. We read the available answers together, each one leaving something uncomfortable behind.

The waiter brought the bill. I signed without adding my title. It seemed the least I could do while a fictional life was asking a much harder question than which room had ordered eggs.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the harsh social story if compromised choices sound worth wrestling with. Room service has accepted my room number and declined the supplementary history of greatness.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1272160/>

P191 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Suzerain

Edition considered: PC base game; Kingdom of Rizia expansion separate

Lead a fictional country through political choices, competing interests and personal relationships, with reports and conversations revealing the consequences of your decisions over time.

What you do. Read briefings, speak with political figures, choose policies and manage relationships that affect the country and the president's family.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense reading, many factions and difficult consequences create heavy tracking; the base-game card excludes the separate Rizia expansion.

Why it might click. As President Anton Rayne, you navigate Sordland's political institutions, economy, international relationships and family life. The attraction is sustained argument: people want incompatible things, and a policy decision can become a personal problem later.

The full catch. This is a dense reading and decision game with a codex, reports and many relationships to remember. Political violence and harsh outcomes add pressure. The inspected description does not establish every input's timing or hold requirements. This card covers the base game, excluding the Rizia expansion.

Try this first. Read the opening political setup and one conversation. Judge whether identifying factions feels intriguing or like an unwanted meeting. A companion can discuss priorities without supplying the supposedly correct ideology.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The President Has Lost Control of the Minibar

I announced my candidacy for president of the penthouse. Tank asked whether my platform included opening the minibar. I promised prosperity.

Suzerain handed us a country with institutions, rivals and citizens who could not eat a speech. Rosa put the hotel bill beside the screen. 'Practice on this first.'

I offered to cut unnecessary spending. Shawna pointed at the ice sculpture of me. I said we should protect national heritage.

Mercedes wanted to know what the political ally was really asking for. Porsche wanted to read the report before choosing. I wanted everyone to appreciate how presidential my jacket looked.

'Nigga, you dressed for a coup at a wedding,' Tank said.

The game made the next decision uncomfortable. I stopped smiling for an audience and read it twice.

Behind me, the sculpture's chin melted into the bucket. Shawna collected the water before it reached the carpet. My first administration survived because somebody else knew what mattered.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the political story when conflicting interests and long consequences sound absorbing. My administration has surrendered the minibar and is negotiating the peaceful removal of its chin.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1207650/>

P192 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Yes, Your Grace

Edition considered: PC first game

Hear a kingdom's petitioners while balancing scarce resources, family needs and dangerous alliances, giving each political choice an immediate human face and cost.

What you do. Listen to requests, allocate resources, speak with family members and consider alliances and preparations as the kingdom's problems develop.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Requests conflict and resources run out; strategic preparation and harsh family outcomes prevent the throne screen from guaranteeing carefree play.

Why it might click. King Eryk hears petitioners, manages scarce resources and tries to protect his family and kingdom. Small requests sit beside larger alliances and threats, giving decisions an immediate human face rather than reducing everything to an abstract national graph.

The full catch. Resources run out, requests conflict and family decisions can hurt. The presentation includes strategic preparation and dangerous events; a throne screen is not a promise of carefree play. Verify the controls and pause behavior in the chosen PC version before assuming all situations wait.

Try this first. Hear the first petition and look at the resources attached to an answer. Ask whether saying no feels satisfyingly consequential or simply unpleasant. Stop without treating a difficult decision as something you must finish tonight.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The King Has Granted Six Requests with Four Coins

I sat in the largest chair and invited petitions. Tank asked for a drink. Rosa asked for the kitchen to stop reheating the same potatoes. Shawna asked for her husband back.

'Nigga, one request at a time.' 'Mine's been pending all evening,' my wife said.

Yes, Your Grace made a throne look less like a reward and more like somewhere other people's needs came to sit on you. Mercedes read a request aloud.

I promised we could help everybody. Porsche turned the screen toward the resources. They had the nerve to remain finite.

The waiter arrived with the new potatoes. Rosa thanked him by name. He smiled and left. A complete act of government had happened without my chair.

Tank lifted his glass. 'You want to grant something useful?'

I stood and gave Shawna the seat beside me. She pulled me into it. The king lost a little elevation and gained a much better evening. Nigga, I endorsed the reform.

Aiden's verdict. Take the throne if hearing people and making imperfect choices sounds compelling. My wife's petition has finally been granted, leaving the king with fewer speeches and better company.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1115690/>

P193 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

Edition considered: PC first game

Investigate digital records for a surveillance programme, deciding which details to submit and discovering how your selections can change somebody else's life and apparent guilt.

What you do. Read messages, profiles and files, connect information, and choose which pieces of evidence to pass onward through the interface.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense records, names and relationships require tracking; evidence-transfer controls and any timing demands need a direct check.

Why it might click. You investigate digital records for a state surveillance program and decide what information to submit. The pleasure lies in connecting messages, profiles and apparent contradictions, then noticing how your selection shapes somebody else's fate.

The full catch. Expect substantial reading, interface switching and memory for names and relationships. Surveillance, terrorism and personal intrusion are central themes. Selecting or transferring evidence needs a direct input check; the premise alone cannot certify mouse-only ease, no dragging or an absence of timed sections.

Try this first. Examine one person's available records and identify two details that might mean different things together. Before forwarding evidence, decide whether the ethical discomfort interests you. A companion can compare interpretations while one person operates the interface.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P193 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Search History Has Asked My Wife to Leave the Room

I projected my browser history onto the penthouse wall to demonstrate transparency. The first search was can velvet survive a hot tub. Shawna folded her arms.

Tank read the next one. 'Nigga, who asks for romantic trousers with emergency pockets?' 'A prepared husband.'

Orwell had made us consider what a digital detail could imply when somebody selected it. I explained that my history needed context. Mercedes said this was the first intelligent thing I had said since turning on the projector.

Porsche wanted to follow the fictional investigation. Rosa wanted the actual wall returned to its previous innocence.

I switched off my history. A normal-sized screen was suddenly enough to discuss what someone had said, what the record showed and what we were only guessing.

Shawna leaned close. 'Did you buy the trousers?' 'Baby, that's privileged.'

She smiled. 'Then stop presenting the privilege to the whole fucking hotel.' I put the projector remote somewhere my reputation could not reach it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the surveillance mystery if selected evidence and its consequences interest you. My trousers remain outside the investigation unless their emergency pockets produce something relevant.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/491950/>

P194 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength

Edition considered: PC sequel

Investigate political information and manipulation in a darker surveillance story, where deciding what to investigate and when affects the narrative that emerges from the records.

What you do. Read digital records, compare accounts, choose investigative leads and consider how selected information shapes a political story.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The time-of-day system adds scheduling pressure; dense records remain, and actual real-time or pause behavior is not fully verified.

Why it might click. This second Orwell story places you in a darker investigation shaped by political narratives and information manipulation. It can reward a reader who enjoys noticing how an apparently factual detail becomes a persuasive weapon.

The full catch. The official description introduces a time-of-day system and decisions about whom to investigate and when. That establishes scheduling pressure inside the story, not a verified real-time countdown or a no-timer guarantee. Expect dense records, unsettling politics and morally compromised work.

Try this first. Read the first assignment and inspect how the interface represents time before making several moves. Decide whether tracking opportunities sounds engaging. Discuss one competing interpretation with a companion without assuming the game offers a neutral choice.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hotel Announces I Returned a Towel

I told the casino host to announce that I had personally restored resources to the community. He asked what I meant. Tank held up the towel I had brought back from the pool.

'Nigga, it's technically true.' Shawna smiled without kindness. 'So is you finally doing the minimum.'

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength made selection and presentation part of the problem. Mercedes read a statement on the screen and wanted to know what had been left out.

I asked the host to mention the quality of the towel. Porsche asked him to mention how long I had kept it. The man quietly stopped taking requests.

At the bar, somebody was trying to relaunch the departed cocaine guest's investment story. Rosa asked whether the actual facts had improved while he was gone.

Nobody answered.

I gave the host the microphone back. The towel went to laundry. Nigga, it had accomplished more by being folded than by appearing in my speech.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when the way information becomes persuasion sounds worth examining. The towel has returned to useful service and will not be giving interviews about my generosity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/633060/>

P195 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Emily is Away

Edition considered: PC first game

Follow a relationship through a nostalgic instant-messenger interface, where brief exchanges and changing profiles convey uncertainty, growing apart and things left unsaid across several years.

What you do. Read messages and profiles, choose responses, and use the messenger's keyboard interactions as conversations move through different stages.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Test the actual typing demand and text size; relationship regret can weigh more heavily than the small interface suggests.

Why it might click. A simulated desktop and instant messenger frame a relationship across several years. Buddy profiles, changing circumstances and brief exchanges turn a familiar piece of technology into a story about growing apart, uncertainty and what people leave unsaid.

The full catch. Reading is central, and the messenger presentation includes keyboard interaction that should be tried directly. Do not assume every message is simply a pointer click or that arbitrary typing works identically across versions. Relationship regret may carry more weight than the small interface suggests.

Try this first. Choose a screen name and follow the first conversation far enough to feel its rhythm. Check the actual typing demand and text size. The useful question is whether the intimacy of messaging appeals, rather than whether you chose the best reply.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Away Message Says I'm with Destiny

I changed my status to WITH DESTINY. Shawna looked over my shoulder. 'Nigga, you're with the room-service menu.' 'Destiny comes hungry.'

Emily is Away put a familiar little chat window in front of us. Short replies, old names, years moving beneath ordinary words. Mercedes read an exchange and went quiet.

I started composing an answer that would explain every feeling anybody had ever misunderstood about me. Tank watched the sentence grow.

'My nigga, you messaging her or submitting a bid?'

Shawna took my actual phone and changed the status to LOOKING FOR A FORK. It was insulting and immediately more useful.

On the game screen, one small response carried more than my paragraph. Porsche asked us to wait before advancing it. We did.

The waiter brought the fork. I thanked him, put the phone face down and let the fictional conversation remain somebody else's. Destiny had arrived carrying cutlery and did not ask for a speech.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the messenger story when a brief reply can bring back an entire era. My actual status remains available to correction by people standing beside me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417860/>

P196 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

We Know the Devil

Edition considered: PC release

Three teenagers at a religious camp face an unsettling story about closeness, exclusion and belonging, with relationships carrying the tension of the visual novel.

What you do. Read the characters' exchanges and make choices about their time together, following how closeness shifts among the three.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Psychological horror, religious pressure and isolation are central; quiet-looking controls do not make the subject gentle or certify all inputs.

Why it might click. This visual novel uses a small cast and a threatening camp setting to explore belonging, exclusion and queer identity. Which characters spend time together matters, creating room for conversation about relationships rather than inventory puzzles or navigation.

The full catch. Psychological horror, religious pressure, isolation and an alarming soundscape are integral to the experience. Light movement demands would not make the subject gentle. The inspected page supports its visual-novel form but does not independently verify every advance input or the absence of all timing demands.

Try this first. Read the opening exchange and listen to a short portion of the atmosphere at a comfortable volume. Decide whether this kind of unease is welcome before pursuing a route. Nobody owes the camp a complete visit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Retreat Has Been Cancelled by the People Invited

I called our late-night gathering a retreat. Mercedes asked what we were retreating from. Tank pointed at the microphone in my hand.

We Know the Devil put three people together with an ugly question about belonging. I had planned an icebreaker requiring everybody to name something they admired about me. Shawna unplugged the speaker.

'Nigga, that's not intimacy. That's customer feedback.'

Rosa pulled another chair into the circle. Porsche sat beside Mercedes. Nobody had to justify where they wanted to be.

The game's unease reached the room. A choice could bring two people closer while leaving somebody outside. I looked at my own little arrangement of seats and quit trying to improve it.

Tank handed me a drink without a joke. I put the microphone down.

For a while we listened. When Mercedes wanted to stop, Porsche closed the game and stayed where she was. Nigga, together could be an ordinary fact if I stopped announcing it like a prize.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the unsettling relationship story only when its horror is welcome. My retreat has been reduced to chairs and company, with no compulsory admiration exercise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435300/>

P197 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

A Normal Lost Phone

Edition considered: PC release

Piece together a fictional person's life through messages, photographs and apps, discovering relationships and circumstances behind a disappearance by reading the details closely.

What you do. Navigate the fictional phone, read message threads, inspect pictures and connect information found across its different apps.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The recorded Steam page says unavailable; establish an existing playable copy, then check small text and navigation across apps.

Why it might click. Messages, pictures and apps form a narrative investigation into Sam's life and disappearance. The appeal is close reading: an ordinary digital object gradually reveals relationships and circumstances that were invisible at first glance.

The full catch. The inspected Steam page says this game is no longer available on that store as of September 20, 2026. Existing access must be established before planning a session. Expect personal, potentially sensitive material, small interface details and searching across apps; the page does not certify input comfort.

Try this first. If you already have a legitimate playable copy, inspect one message thread and test the fictional phone's navigation. Ask whether piecing together a person's circumstances feels compelling, and stop before curiosity becomes an obligation to finish.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Missing Phone Contains Fourteen Unflattering Versions of Me

Porsche held up a phone she had found under my chair. I announced that its contents would reveal a life of exceptional taste. She opened the photographs.

Tank leaned over. 'Nigga, why you got nine pictures of your elbow?' 'Lighting study.'

A Normal Lost Phone invited us to understand a fictional life through a device. My own device invited the room to understand that I could not find the front camera.

Shawna took it before Porsche reached the beach photographs. My wife looked at one, then at me. 'Baby, you asked me not to send this.' 'I believe in preserving art privately.'

She locked the screen. The joke belonged to us; the rest of the room could live without the image.

Mercedes returned to the game listing and noticed the availability catch. We checked that before planning anything.

Tank handed me the phone face down. 'Your elbow available everywhere, though.' Nigga, the distribution was beyond my control.

Aiden's verdict. Consider the fictional phone only after establishing a playable copy. My elbow archive remains technically available, but Shawna has suspended its international exhibition programme.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 523210 identifies A Normal Lost Phone and explicitly states it is no longer available on Steam, observed September 20, 2026. Premise comes from the product description. Existing access, controls and availability elsewhere are not established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/523210/>

P198 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

Edition considered: PC release

Reconstruct Laura's life through her fictional phone, connecting personal and professional details to understand the circumstances behind her disappearance rather than exploring a physical landscape.

What you do. Read messages, examine photographs and navigate apps, separating what the phone shows from what you infer about its owner.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Close reading and app navigation are central; difficult personal circumstances and unverified control details remain meaningful catches.

Why it might click. A fictional found phone holds Laura's photographs, messages and apps. Following connections between professional life, relationships and social habits creates a story through investigation rather than through moving an avatar around a large landscape.

The full catch. Expect close reading, app navigation, inference and difficult personal circumstances. The official game site verifies the premise, while a retailer verifies this PC edition; neither settles every control demand or current availability elsewhere. Automated Steam matches were wrong, so those unrelated products are excluded from this card.

Try this first. Start by examining the fictional phone layout and a short exchange. Compare an observation with an interpretation, keeping them separate. Decide whether the interface is legible and the personal investigation welcome before following every available thread.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P198 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Laura's Calendar Is Not Evidence About My Wife

I suggested reconstructing the party from everybody's calendar. Shawna opened mine. It contained DINNER, TRIUMPH and a private appointment titled ASK NICELY.

Tank looked up. 'Nigga, who's that with?' 'Mind your business.' 'Then close the projector.'

Laura's Story required noticing connections inside a fictional phone. I began drawing conclusions before Mercedes had finished reading. Porsche moved the screen away from my pointing finger.

'You got a fact?' 'I got a feeling.' 'Then let the fact finish getting here.'

Rosa collected a plate and asked what Laura's actual messages showed. We looked. My beautiful theory lost three of its four legs.

Shawna closed my real calendar. 'Your last appointment still open?' I glanced at her. She smiled and put the phone in her bag.

I sat back. The fictional investigation could continue without turning every private detail into entertainment. Later, if my wife wanted, I had one ordinary question to ask and no audience to impress.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the fictional clues when careful attention to an ordinary life sounds compelling. My private calendar has left the screen and will be keeping its own appointments.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official game site anotherlostphone.com is credited to Accidental Queens and directly describes the narrative investigation, phone apps, friendships, professional life and disappearance. GameHouse separately verifies the PC title. Incorrect automated Steam matches were excluded. Neither source certifies full-path timing or holds; checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://anotherlostphone.com/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamehouse.com/games/another-lost-phone-lauras-story>

P199 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut

Edition considered: PC Pristine Cut

Question a confident narrator through a branching psychological-horror story, where choices and beliefs reshape the princess, the situation and the meaning of what happens.

What you do. Listen to narration, read choices and decide what to believe or do as the story changes around those decisions.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Intense violence, gore and suicide themes are explicit; voice acting does not settle every timed or held-input question.

Why it might click. The Pristine Cut expands a fully voiced psychological-horror visual novel whose branching story turns on what you do, believe and question. Narration, performance and shifting interpretations are major attractions for somebody who enjoys arguing with a story's apparent authority.

The full catch. The developer explicitly warns of intense violence, gore, partial nudity, strong language and suicide themes. This is a substantial content catch, not a gentle princess tale. Full voice acting does not establish no timed or held inputs; check the exact interface before making that assumption.

Try this first. Read the content notice first. If the premise still appeals, hear the initial narration and inspect how dialogue advances. Choose whether to continue for its argument and atmosphere, without accepting the narrator's urgency as your own.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Narrator Sounds Like a Man Selling Me a Suite

The narrator told us what had to be done. I admired his confidence. Shawna asked why. I said a man should respect a clear introduction.

Slay the Princess made that a very poor starting position. Mercedes folded her arms. Porsche leaned closer. Tank looked at me as if the game had personally requested his testimony.

'Nigga, if confidence meant trustworthy, you'd own my house.'

I tried to defend the voice. Shawna picked up the hotel brochure I had signed without reading. It promised a private pool; the pool had twelve strangers and a saxophonist in it.

The next line on the screen made the room quieter. We checked the content notice again. Nobody needed to prove anything by continuing.

Rosa chose another chair, ready to leave the story if she wanted. I moved my leg out of her way.

Tank nodded at the narrator. 'Let him sell the basement to somebody else.' Nigga, even my speaking voice had started looking suspicious.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the horror only if its argument with authority sounds welcome. My hotel brochure has been admitted as evidence against judging a narrator by confidence alone.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified exact Steam title Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut, app 1989270. Publisher description supports branching fully voiced psychological horror and expanded Pristine Cut; developer mature-content notice supplies the explicit content catches. No full-playthrough timing or hold audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1989270/>

P200 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Scarlet Hollow

Edition considered: PC episodic release; current completion status must be checked

Enter a branching horror mystery where character traits, family relationships and a troubled town shape what you notice and how people respond to you.

What you do. Choose traits, read conversations, investigate unsettling events and make decisions that affect relationships and the story's branches.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The recorded release is unfinished; disturbing imagery remains despite the no-jumpscare statement and declared play without timed input.

Why it might click. Character traits and choices shape a branching horror mystery around a family visit and a troubled town. Conversations can reveal different details, making personality and relationships part of the investigation rather than merely decoration around clues.

The full catch. The inspected description lists five available episodes and another major update before the conclusion as of September 20, 2026: this is unfinished. The developer declares no jumpscare and Steam lists play without timed input, but disturbing imagery and tension remain. Neither statement certifies every hold or device.

Try this first. Inspect the opening traits and read the first family exchange. Decide whether you want a tense serial whose ending is still pending. A companion can debate impressions while the person playing keeps authority over the actual choices.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Family Reunion Has Reserved a Chair for the Thing Outside

I set an extra place at the party for the mysterious arrival Scarlet Hollow had made me expect. Tank asked who was coming. I said the town had secrets.

'Nigga, this hotel got secrets. One of them is where they keep hot coffee.'

A family visit, a funeral and a place with something wrong beneath it sounded like a story Mercedes wanted to hear. She chose a trait before I finished explaining which trait I thought suited her.

Shawna turned to me. 'You can have your own opinion without assigning hers.'

The curtain moved. I looked over sharply. Rosa was closing the balcony because the room had become cold.

Porsche checked how much of the story was available. We noted the unfinished ending before settling in. Even my enthusiasm could not invent another episode.

Tank stole the extra chair for Rosa's feet. 'Whatever's outside can knock.' Nigga, the family reunion acquired better hospitality the moment I stopped furnishing it for monsters.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the ominous family story if its serial form appeals, including the unfinished conclusion. Any creature arriving at our party must accept that Rosa has the chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description on September 20, 2026 says five episodes available and another major update before the conclusion. Developer states no jumpscare; the Steam category declares playable without timed input. Those are sourced declarations, not a complete no-hold or no-distress certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1609230/>

The Suite Was Booked Until Morning

The hotel manager arrived to ask whether we wanted the room for another night. He had a clean jacket, a tired smile and the courage of a man whose commission depended on my inability to finish anything quietly.

'What makes you think we're leaving?' I asked. He glanced at the breakfast carts waiting in the hall. Nigga had brought evidence.

The party had thinned into the people I wanted there when the music stopped. Mercedes sat barefoot at the piano bench. Porsche had finally put one phone away. Tank was asleep against Rosa's shoulder, denying it whenever she moved.

'I heard that,' he said. 'Nobody spoke,' Rosa told him. 'I'm ahead.'

Shawna stood by the window looking at the city. Her shoes were in my hand. I could have claimed I was making a gallant gesture. She had handed them to me after I stepped on the hem of her dress and asked what else I was doing with all that strength.

The games were still on the table. Nobody had finished the whole shelf. Nobody looked disappointed by this tremendous failure of ambition.

We had found conversations worth another visit. A bartender who let people talk. A family decision somebody wanted to argue about later. A strange place whose people stayed in the room after its screen went dark.

I wanted to give the evening a title. Mercedes wanted to hear the last line of her song without the hotel air conditioner rattling over it. Porsche walked over and turned the fan down.

That was the kind of support a nigga could actually use.

The manager asked again about the extra night. I looked at Shawna. She looked at the bed visible through the open doorway, then back at me.

'You got a speech about it?' she asked. 'I can make a compelling case.' 'Make a short one.'

I held up the shoes. 'I've already got your luggage.'

She laughed. The manager smiled at the carpet. Professional nigga. Knew when a sale was none of his business.

Rosa touched Tank's cheek. 'Come on.' 'Dessert?' 'We ate it.' 'Both?'

She kissed him. He stopped looking for the second plate.

Mercedes called me over before they left. She wanted the recording of the song from the room microphones. Not the crowd, not my introduction, not a highlight reel with my face at the start.

'Just the song,' she said. 'I got you.' 'Say what I asked for.'

I said it. She nodded. A simple exchange. No audience required.

Porsche slipped the recording drive into Mercedes's hand. 'Already done.'

Nigga, I had arrived at my own helpful moment after the help.

I could have made a joke. Instead I watched Mercedes close her fingers around it. The little relief in her shoulders belonged to her. It did not need me stepping in front of it.

At the bar, the host had left a note about the guest with the cocaine. His things were gone, his car had been arranged, and the hotel wanted to know who had called his investment pitch a hostage situation.

Porsche lifted one finger without looking up.

The manager decided he did not need a written statement.

Tank woke properly at the mention of a car. He checked Rosa had her coat, checked Mercedes and Porsche had theirs, then asked whether I knew where my keys were.

I held up Shawna's shoes.

'Nigga,' he said, 'those ain't interchangeable.'

Shawna took the shoes and put her hand in mine. 'He's staying.'

My brother grinned. Rosa pulled him toward the door before he could ask the sort of question married people should leave other married people to answer privately.

The elevator opened. My giant face split again.

'Still ugly in the middle,' Tank called.

'Nigga, get home.'

The doors closed on his laugh.

I switched off the stage lights. Shawna left one lamp on beside the sofa. The game we had chosen waited where we left it, with a conversation still unfinished. That felt right. A good night did not owe me an ending to everything it had started.

My wife kissed me, slow enough to interrupt the next sentence before I spent it.

'Now,' she said, 'you can tell me what happens when you arrive.'

I put the controller safely on the table.

The hotel kept the suite until morning.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.